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United States Patent	12403290
Kind Code	B2
Date of Patent	September 02, 2025
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Pleated or folded catheter-mounted balloon

Abstract

A catheter-mounted balloon includes an inflatable chamber defining a volume expandable from a deflated state to an inflated state, the inflatable chamber having a distal transition portion, a proximal transition portion, and a cylindrical body portion disposed between the distal transition portion and the proximal transition portion. The cylindrical body portion of the inflatable chamber includes a pleat zone having a pleat when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. The catheter-mounted balloon further includes an electrode disposed along a wall of the inflatable chamber. The pleat traverses the electrode such that the electrode is pleated as well.

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Appl. No.:	18/341895
Filed:	June 27, 2023

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier	Publication Date
US 20230338713 A1	Oct. 26, 2023

Related U.S. Application Data

continuation parent-doc US 17239017 20210423 US 11707608 child-doc US 18341895
continuation parent-doc US 14484784 20140912 US 10987494 20210427 child-doc US 17239017
us-provisional-application US 61877923 20130913

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: **A61B18/14** (20060101); **A61M25/10** (20130101); A61B18/00 (20060101); A61B18/18 (20060101); A61B18/20 (20060101); A61B90/00 (20160101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC **A61M25/1002** (20130101); **A61B18/1492** (20130101); A61B2018/0022 (20130101); A61B2018/00232 (20130101); A61B2018/00238 (20130101); A61B2018/00434 (20130101); A61B2018/00577 (20130101); A61B2018/1435 (20130101); A61B2018/1465 (20130101); A61B18/1815 (20130101); A61B18/20 (20130101); A61B2090/3966 (20160201); A61B2218/002 (20130101); A61M2025/1004 (20130101)

Field of Classification Search

CPC: A61B (5/0422); A61B (2018/00029); A61B (2018/00166); A61B (2018/0022); A61B (2018/00238); A61B (2018/00267); A61B (2018/00375); A61B (2018/00577); A61B (2018/00839); A61B (2018/1407); A61B (2018/1435); A61B (2018/1467); A61B (2018/1475); A61B (18/1492); A61B (2090/3966); A61B (17/320068); A61B (18/1815); A61B (18/20); A61B (2018/00434); A61M (25/1002)

USPC: 606/41

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Background/Summary

CROSS REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) This application is a continuation of U.S. application Ser. No. 17/239,017, filed Apr. 23, 2021, and entitled “Pleated or Folded Catheter-Mounted Balloon,” which is a continuation of U.S. application Ser. No. 14/484,784, now U.S. Pat. No. 10,987,494, filed Sep. 12, 2014, and entitled, “Pleated or Folded Catheter-Mounted Balloon,” which claims priority to and the benefit of U.S. Provisional Application Ser. No. 61/877,923, filed on Sep. 13, 2013, entitled “A Pleated or Folded Catheter-Mounted Balloon,” each of which are hereby incorporated herein by reference in their entirety. (2) This application is related to the following patents or patent applications, each of which is hereby incorporated herein by reference

in its entirety: PCT/US2012/057967, filed on Sep. 28, 2012, U.S. Provisional Application Ser. No. 61/541,765, filed on Sep. 30, 2011, U.S. Provisional Application Ser. No. 61/593,147, filed on Jan. 31, 2012, U.S. Provisional Application Ser. No. 61/113,228, filed Dec. 11, 2008; U.S. Provisional Application Ser. No. 61/160,204, filed Mar. 13, 2009; U.S. Provisional Application Ser. No. 61/179,654, filed May 19, 2009; U.S. Patent Application Publication No. 2010/0204560, filed Nov. 11, 2009; U.S. Provisional Application Ser. No. 61/334,154, filed May 12, 2010; and U.S. patent application Ser. No. 13/106,658, filed May 12, 2011.

BACKGROUND

(1) Hypertension and other related cardiovascular disorders are major health concerns affecting many adults in the developed world. These conditions can be especially severe for patients with so-called drug-resistant hypertension (e.g., those unable to achieve target blood-pressure values despite multiple drug therapies at their proper doses). Renal denervation may be used for the treatment of hypertension, cardiovascular disorders, chronic renal diseases, or other related diseases or disease states. It is believed renal denervation has an impact on sympathetic renal nerve activity.

(2) Renal denervation can be performed using minimally invasive procedures that use balloon-mounted catheters to navigate through blood vessels to deliver treatment to target sites in the blood vessel. Conventional catheters have balloons that “bunch up” when pulled or forced through the catheter body, often forming tight random non-deterministic folds. This makes insertion through the guide catheter and pull-back into the guide catheter difficult as the nature of the folds greatly increases the force required to insert or withdraw the balloon catheter.

SUMMARY

(3) This disclosure describes systems and methods for pleating a catheter-mounted balloon (e.g., by thermal, mechanical, or chemical means), such that the balloon preferentially folds in a predictable pattern along the pleat lines when collapsed and pushed through the catheter. By fabricating the balloon to fold automatically according to pre-determined pleat patterns, the force required to insert or withdraw the balloon can be greatly reduced, as compared to a non-pleated balloon, thus lowering the forces required to insert or withdraw a balloon catheter. Additionally or alternatively, the pleats may be configured such that inflation of the balloon requires less pressure than in a typical system, for example, by using looser pleats than in balloons without pre-pleating. The pre-pleating may also permit use of a smaller catheter in some cases. For ease of illustration, embodiments are discussed in the context of devices, methods, and systems for achieving renal denervation for the treatment of hypertension, other cardiovascular disorders, and chronic renal diseases. Illustrative embodiments are described in the context of using energy-based devices (e.g., radio-frequency based devices) and methods to reduce renal sympathetic activity in the renal nerves without causing damage to non-target cells. However, the embodiments may be adapted and applied in other types of applications, including other neuromodulation devices, without departing from the scope of the disclosure.

(4) The systems, devices, and methods described herein can be used to affect neural communication to and from the one or both kidneys to improve cardio-renal function of the patient, such that the kidney continues to function in the patient. Thus, renal nerve fibers can be deactivated (permanently or temporarily) without being completely physically severed (e.g., without fully cutting).

(5) In one aspect, a catheter-mounted balloon includes an inflatable chamber defining a volume expandable from a deflated state to an inflated state, the inflatable chamber having a distal transition portion, a proximal transition portion, and a cylindrical body portion disposed between the distal transition portion and the proximal transition portion. The cylindrical body portion of the inflatable chamber includes a pleat zone having a pleat when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. The catheter-mounted balloon further includes an electrode disposed along a wall of the inflatable chamber. The pleat traverses the electrode such that the electrode is pleated as well.

In one example, the electrode may be helical around a longitudinal axis of the inflatable chamber.

(6) According to some implementations, the inflatable chamber defines at least one irrigation aperture to allow fluid to flow from within the balloon to outside the balloon when the balloon is in the inflated state. The irrigation aperture is at least partially unobstructed by the pleat when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. By avoiding complete obstruction of the pleat, these embodiments may reduce the likelihood of damage to the irrigation aperture shapes and may facilitate providing irrigation for the balloon even when the balloon is not fully inflated. In one example, the at least one irrigation aperture is disposed between the pleat and a side of the electrode.

(7) According to some implementations, the pleat zone having the pleat defines an opening between a first side of the pleat and a second side of the pleat when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. Such an opening can reduce the likelihood of pleating the inflatable chamber tightly to the point of damaging the material of the inflatable chamber, damaging any electrode pleated along with the inflatable chamber, or requiring excessive application of pressure to unfold and inflate the inflatable chamber.

(8) In some implementations, the pleat extends at least partially into the proximal transition portion of the inflatable chamber. For example, at least a portion of the pleat can be substantially parallel to a longitudinal axis of the cylindrical body portion of the inflatable chamber when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. Additionally or alternatively, at least a portion of the pleat can be a spiral around the longitudinal axis of the cylindrical body portion when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. Additionally or alternatively, at least a portion of the pleat is a substantially zig-zag pattern along the longitudinal axis of the cylindrical body portion when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. As yet another additional or alternative example, at least a portion of the pleat is substantially parallel to an edge of the electrode.

(9) The inflatable chamber may be collapsible along the pleat in response to a decrease in the volume of the inflatable chamber as the inflatable chamber is deflated from the inflated state to the deflated state.

(10) In certain implementations, the diameter of the cylindrical body portion of the inflatable chamber is in any of the ranges between about 0.01 inches and about 0.03 inches, between about 0.01 inches and about 0.015 inches, or between about 0.015 inches and about 0.019 inches, when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. In certain implementations, the diameter of the cylindrical body portion of the inflatable may be less than about 0.01 inches when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state.

(11) According to another aspect, a catheter includes a pleated catheter-mounted balloon as described herein, and a guidewire for delivering the catheter-mounted balloon to an intravascular treatment site, while the inflatable chamber of the delivered catheter-mounted balloon is in the deflated state.

(12) In yet another aspect, an energy-based system is provided. The system comprises a nerve modulation device including a balloon as described herein positioned in a vicinity of neural fibers that innervate a kidney of a patient, where the energy-based device is configured to alter neural communication to and from the kidney.

(13) In yet another aspect, a method is provided for performing a renal neuromodulation procedure to treat a heat-related condition using a catheter-mounted balloon, a catheter, or an energy-based system as described herein.

(14) This description may use the phrases “in embodiments,” “in some embodiments,” or “in certain embodiments,” which may each refer to one or more of the same or different embodiments in accordance with the present disclosure.

(15) As used herein, the terms proximal and distal include a direction or a position along a longitudinal axis of a catheter or medical instrument. The term “proximal” includes the end of the catheter or medical instrument closer to the operator, while the term “distal” includes the end of the

catheter or medical instrument closer to the patient. For example, a first point is proximal to a second point if it is closer to the operator end of the catheter or medical instrument than the second point. The term “operator” includes any medical professional (e.g., doctor, surgeon, nurse, or the like) performing a medical procedure involving the use of aspects of the present disclosure described herein.

(16) Embodiments can include one or more of the following advantages.

(17) A balloon that is fabricated to fold according to pre-determined pleat patterns can be designed to fold into a substantially uniform tubular shape, which can lead to a reduction in the force required to insert or withdraw the balloon. The tightness of pleats can be arranged to allow a pleat to retain an opening between its two sides when the balloon is deflated, and by so doing, reduce the pressure required for inflating the balloon below that required for balloons with tighter pleats. Compared with unpleated balloons, balloons pleated to fold in a preferential configuration can be compatible with a wider range of guide catheters having smaller inner diameters and less lubricious inner catheter surfaces, resulting in smaller punctures during minimal-invasive surgery and shorter recovery times.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

(1) The foregoing and other objects and advantages will be apparent upon consideration of the following detailed description, taken in conjunction with the accompanying drawings, in which like reference characters refer to like parts throughout, and in which:

(2) FIG. 1A is a side view of an illustrative catheter-mounted balloon;

(3) FIG. 1B is a cross-section of the balloon in FIG. 1A when the catheter-mounted balloon is in the inflated state;

(4) FIG. 1C is a cross-section of the balloon in FIG. 1A when the catheter-mounted balloon is in the deflated state;

(5) FIG. 2A is a perspective cross-section view of an inflatable chamber of a catheter-mounted balloon with three pleat zones;

(6) FIG. 2B is a cross-section of the inflatable chamber in FIG. 2A;

(7) FIGS. 3 to 7 are cross-sections of example catheter-mounted balloons with pleats;

(8) FIGS. 8 to 11 are side views of example pleating patterns of catheter-mounted balloons with pleats;

(9) FIG. 12A is a schematic representation of an energy-delivery system for providing renal neuromodulation according to some embodiments;

(10) FIG. 12B illustrates an energy delivery device in use within a renal artery according to some embodiments; and

DETAILED DESCRIPTION

(11) To provide an overall understanding of the systems, devices, and methods described herein, particular embodiments of the present disclosure are described herein with reference to the accompanying drawings. However, the disclosed embodiments are merely examples of the disclosure and may be embodied in various forms.

(12) FIG. 1A is a side view of a catheter-mounted balloon **300** without pleats. Balloon **300** is shown in an inflated state, secured to an elongate member (which may be a catheter shaft) **310**.

FIG. 1B is a corresponding cross-section **320** of balloon **300** when balloon **300** is expanded or in an inflated state, and FIG. 1C is a cross-section **330** of balloon **300** when balloon **300** is collapsed or in a deflated state. Cross-sections **320** and **330** are taken at the anterior-posterior axis **340** shown in FIG. 1A.

(13) Balloon **300** includes an inflatable chamber **301** defining a volume expandable from a deflated

state to an inflated state, and one or more electrodes **308** for providing treatment intravascularly to various treatment sites, including for providing an energy signal to renal nerves within the renal artery to achieve renal denervation. In the example of balloon **300**, the electrode **308** is a single helical electrode disposed on a wall of the balloon. However, any suitable electrode, including any non-helical electrode (e.g., a point-by-point electrode), may be used. In some embodiments, the electrode **308** is a rigid electrode that does not fold along with the balloon.

(14) Inflatable chamber **301** includes a distal transition portion **302**, a cylindrical body portion **304**, and a proximal transition portion **306**. Distal transition portion **302** and proximal transition portion **306** are frustoconical shapes that taper inwardly away from cylindrical body portion **304**. In this embodiment, electrode **308** is in a helical or spiral configuration around a longitudinal axis of cylindrical body portion **302** of inflatable chamber **301**. The helical shape of electrode **308** can increase the likelihood of delivery of RF energy to nerves that are not uniformly distributed around a circumference of a renal artery. It should be appreciated, however, that, without departing from the scope of the present disclosure, electrode **308** may take on any suitable shape or configuration. Additionally or alternatively, more than one electrode may be disposed on the inflatable chamber **301**.

(15) Electrode **308** delivers energy to a tissue or vascular region when inflatable chamber **301** is in the inflated state and in contact with or is nearly in contact with the tissue or vascular region. In some embodiments, at least one irrigation aperture (not shown in FIGS. **1A-1C**) is defined by cylindrical body portion **302** to facilitate fluid flow from within inflatable chamber **301** to outside inflatable chamber **301** when inflatable chamber **301** is in the inflated state. Irrigation through one or more irrigation apertures can provide cooling of the wall of inflatable chamber **301**, electrode **308**, and/or tissue in the vicinity of the electrode **308** during treatment.

(16) In general, balloon **300** is delivered through a guide catheter (not shown) to a vessel such as a renal artery, where balloon **300** is pushed out from the guide catheter to be placed in proximity to a vascular wall at a treatment site. Once balloon **300** is in position, fluid is pumped from a reservoir (not shown) into inflatable chamber **301** from proximal transition portion **306** in a closed loop or an open loop configuration. For example, saline may be pumped under constant flow through an irrigation lumen (not shown) to cause inflatable chamber **301** to expand or inflate until an external wall (or a portion thereof) of inflatable chamber **301** makes contact with an inner wall of the vessel. Once fully inflated, inflatable chamber **301** may assume the shape of cross-section **320** shown in FIG. **1B**, and electrode **308** on the inflatable chamber **301** may assume the helical configuration shown in FIG. **1A**. Energy is delivered to electrode **308**, which may be coupled to a conductive guide wire (not shown). Once the energy delivery process terminates, fluid flow is stopped, and inflatable chamber **301** collapses into the deflated state. Deflated balloon **300** is then pulled back into the catheter and retrieved from the treatment site.

(17) FIG. **1C** shows an example of a cross-section **330** of balloon **300**, when balloon **300** is in a deflated or collapsed state, for example, when forced through a guide catheter. It should be appreciated that, without pleats to guide preferential folding of balloon **300**, the cross-section **330** shown in FIG. **1C** is illustrative, as the cross-section **330** may vary considerably each time the balloon **300** is in the deflated or collapsed state. As fully or partially deflated balloon **300** is pushed or pulled through the guide catheter, depending on the shape of inflatable chamber **301**, and material properties of inflatable chamber **301** and electrode **308**, balloon **300** may tightly or loosely fold onto itself and “bunch up,” thus requiring a large force to insert or withdraw the balloon **300** relative to the guide catheter. During balloon deployment, the distal end of the guide catheter may be protected with a silicon seal that provides additional resistance to movement of the balloon.

(18) To exert more control over the shape and configuration of balloon **300** in a fully or partially deflated state so balloon **300** may more easily move out of and into a guide catheter, pleating (e.g., thermal pleating) may be applied to balloon **300** during the manufacturing process, such that balloon **300** folds in preferential configurations when pushed through the guide catheter, and

collapses in similar preferential configurations when pulled back into the guide catheter. By pleating and allowing balloon **300** to fold according to pre-determined pleat patterns, the force required to insert or withdraw the balloon through the catheter can be greatly reduced, thus facilitating successful deployment of balloon **300**.

(19) Inflatable chamber **301** may comprise a layer of shape memory material such as shape-memory polymers which can retain or recover different shapes and can transition easily between those shapes with minimal force. Such shape restoration properties help retain preferential shape configuration after inflation of balloon **300** and subsequent deflation processes. Examples of shape memory materials include polyurethane-based shape memory polymers, and polyether foams.

(20) FIG. 2A is a perspective cross-section of an illustrative pleated inflatable chamber **335**, which includes a proximal transition portion **336** and a cylindrical body portion **337**. Inflatable chamber **335** can be used, for example, in place of inflatable chamber **301** in FIG. 1A. For clarity of illustration, only a fraction of cylindrical body portion **337** is shown in FIG. 2A. FIG. 2B shows a corresponding cross-sectional view of the inflatable chamber **335** in FIG. 2A. In both figures, pleated inflatable chamber **335** is in a deflated or partially deflated state. Cylindrical body portion **337** includes three longitudinal pleats **340a**, **340b** and **340c**. As used herein, a “pleat” includes a fold or a bend of a surface, and a “pleat zone” includes a portion of the surface that includes the pleat. For example, pleat **340a** is included in pleat zone **343a** bordered by folds **341** and **345**. Pleat zone **343a** includes pleat **340a** as well as a first side **342** of pleat **340a** and a second side **344** of pleat **340a**. In some embodiments, inflatable chamber **301** is collapsible along the pleats in response to a decrease in the volume of inflatable chamber **301** as inflatable chamber **301** is deflated from the inflated state to the deflated state.

(21) In the pleated inflatable chamber **335** shown in FIG. 2A, pleat zone **343a** defines an opening **346** between first side **342** of pleat **343a** and second side **344** of pleat **343a** when the balloon is in a fully or partially deflated state. A loose pleat in a pleat zone with an opening (e.g., pleat zone **343a** with opening **346**) allows the application of a lower fluid pressure when a catheter-mounted balloon is inflated. For example, a loosely pleated balloon may be properly inflated when the fluid pressure is in the range from about 5 psi to about 100 psi, or from 10 psi to 50 psi, while a tightly pleated balloon (e.g., a balloon pleated with two-layer gaps) may require a fluid pressure in the range from about 100 psi to about 400 psi. Additionally or alternatively, loose pleating can reduce the likelihood of damage to the mechanical integrity of the balloon.

(22) In addition, depending on the material composition of inflatable chamber **335**, the manufacturing process which may involve thermal treatment, and the operational pressure of the inflatable chamber **335**, pleats **340a**, **340b**, **340c** within inflatable chamber **335** may maintain their shape within the normal operational pressure range of the inflatable chamber **335**. In other words, the pleats **340a**, **340b**, **340c** can self-recover and fold back into a preferential configuration to facilitate the retrieval of the balloon **300** back into the guide catheter.

(23) As compared to a balloon without pleats, pleating of inflatable chamber **335** of balloon **300** reduces the circumferential length of the inflatable chamber **335** when the inflatable chamber **335** is in a fully or partially deflated state. This reduced circumferential length can facilitate, for example, the use of smaller diameter guide catheters which can be accommodated by smaller punctures during minimally invasive surgery, and consequently can reduce patient recovery time. In some embodiments, the diameter of a pleated cylindrical body portion **337** of inflatable chamber **335** is less than about 0.025 inch when inflatable chamber **335** is in the deflated state. In certain embodiments, the diameter of pleated cylindrical body portion **337** of inflatable chamber **335** is less than about 0.019 inch when inflatable chamber **335** is in the deflated state. In some embodiments, the diameter of pleated cylindrical body portion **337** of inflatable chamber **335** is in any of the ranges between about 0.01 inches and about 0.015 inches, between about 0.01 inch and 0.03 inches, between about 0.015 inches and about 0.019 inches when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state. In some embodiments, the diameter of pleated cylindrical body portion **337** of

inflatable chamber **335** is less than about 0.01 inch when inflatable chamber **335** is in the deflated state.

(24) Pleats **343a**, **343b**, and **343c** are sharp folds that can be viewed as the intersecting line between two surfaces. In some embodiments, pleats **343a**, **343b**, and **343c** may be soft, with substantially round corners that can bend and fold into a predetermined configuration. Soft pleats are advantageous, for example, in embodiments wherein one or more pleats **343a**, **343b**, **343c** traverse an electrode (e.g., electrode **118** in FIG. **1A**) such that the electrode is pleated. For example, as compared to sharp pleats, soft pleats may be useful for reducing the likelihood that electrical properties of the traversed electrode will be compromised by the pleat while still facilitating the use of reduced force to insert and withdraw a balloon within a guide catheter.

(25) Although three pleats are shown in FIGS. **2A** and **2B**, in various embodiments, a catheter-mounted balloon may include any suitable number of pleats, pleat shapes, pleat sizes, and pleat patterns.

(26) FIGS. **3-7** are cross-sections of exemplary pleated inflatable chambers, with each inflatable chambers shown in a deflated state.

(27) FIG. **3** is a cross-sectional view of an inflatable chamber with two radially symmetrical pleats, which may facilitate rotation of a catheter-mounted balloon through a guide catheter (e.g., a guide catheter having a lubricious inner surface and/or a guide catheter having grooves complementary to the pleat pattern). In the examples shown in FIGS. **2A** and **2B**, pleats extend longitudinally across the cylindrical body portion **337**. In some embodiments, however, the pleats may be a spiral around the longitudinal axis of the inflatable chamber when the inflatable chamber is in a fully or partially deflated state, and/or may form a substantially zig-zag pattern along the longitudinal axis of the cylindrical body portion when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state.

(28) FIG. **4** is a cross-sectional view of an inflatable chamber with three radially symmetrical pleats. As compared to pleats **340a**, **340b**, and **340c** in FIGS. **2A** and **2B** which are in adjacent pleat zones, pleats **410a**, **410b**, and **410c** shown in FIG. **4** are located in respective pleat zones **420a**, **420b**, and **420c** spaced apart on the surface of the inflatable chamber.

(29) FIG. **5** is a cross-sectional view of an inflatable chamber with four pleats, where the orientation of the pleats is configured so the circumferential shape of the inflatable chamber is circular.

(30) FIG. **6** is a cross-sectional view of an inflatable chamber with five pleats. In general, any suitable number of pleats may be set (e.g., thermally set) into the inflatable chamber of a catheter-mounted balloon.

(31) FIG. **7** illustrates an inflatable chamber with four soft pleats. As described herein, soft pleats may be used when a pleat traverses an electrode disposed on the inflatable chamber, where traversal of the electrode by the pleat causes the electrode to be pleated as well and, as compared to a sharp pleat, the soft pleat is less likely to impact the electrical properties and/or structural integrity of the electrode.

(32) FIGS. **8-11** are side views of example pleating patterns of pleated balloons, each balloon including one or more pleats, one or more electrodes and, optionally, defining one or more irrigation apertures.

(33) Referring to FIG. **8**, a balloon **800** includes an inflatable chamber **801** and an electrode **808**, with electrode **808** disposed (e.g., diagonally disposed) on inflatable chamber **801**. In the illustrated example, inflatable chamber **801** includes two pleats **810** and **820**, each of which extends across electrode **808**. It should be appreciated, however, one of pleats **810** and **820** can be arranged to extend across electrode **808** while the other of pleats **810** and **820** does not extend across electrode **808**. Additionally or alternatively, it should be appreciated that inflatable chamber **801** can include fewer or greater pleats without departing from the scope of the present disclosure.

(34) In the deflated state, the cross-section of inflatable chamber **801** may be as shown in FIG. **3**. Inflatable chamber **801** includes a proximal transition portion **802**, a cylindrical body portion **804**,

and a distal transition portion **806**. In this example, pleats **810** and **820** extend longitudinally along cylindrical body portion **804**, from proximal transition portion **802** to distal transition portion **806**. (35) In this example, irrigation apertures **830** flank both sides of electrode **808** to cool the electrode during energy delivery. In some embodiments, irrigation apertures **830** are placed and designed so that, in a fully or partially deflated state of inflatable chamber **801**, pleats **810** and **820** do not fully obstruct irrigation apertures **830** and, thus, do not entirely block fluid flow through irrigation apertures **830**, reducing the likelihood of pressure buildup within inflatable chamber **801**. In some embodiments, irrigation apertures **830** may be partially blocked by a pleat when the inflation chamber **801** is in the deflated state.

(36) Pleats **810** and **820** may fold in pre-determined directions. In this example, pleat **810** and pleat **820** may fold to the right, in direction **840**, and no irrigation apertures are disposed immediately next to pleats **810** and **820**.

(37) Referring to FIG. 9, a balloon **900** includes an inflatable chamber **901** and an electrode **908**. Inflatable chamber **901** includes three pleats **910**, **920**, and **930**, and electrode **908** is disposed on inflatable chamber **901** such that each pleat **910**, **920**, and **930** extends across electrode **908**. In a fully or partially deflated state, the cross-section of inflatable chamber **901** may be as shown in FIG. 2B or FIG. 3. In the example shown in FIG. 9, pleats **910**, **920**, and **930** extend longitudinally along the cylindrical body portion **904** and also into proximal transition portion **902** of inflatable chamber **901**. The full or partial extension of pleats **910**, **920**, and **930** into proximal transition portion **902** may facilitate winding of inflatable chamber **901** and electrode **908** when balloon **900** is pulled back into a guide catheter after energy delivery. Additionally or alternatively, pleats **815** and **825** may be included in proximal portion **902** to facilitate the folding of balloon **900**. Additionally or alternatively, one or more pleats may extend into distal portion **906**.

(38) Referring now to FIG. 10, a balloon **1000** includes an inflatable chamber **1001** and an electrode **1008**. Inflatable chamber **1001** includes six pleats **1010**, and electrode **1008** is disposed on inflatable chamber **1001** such that pleats **1010** do not cross electrode **1008**. Pleats **1010** and, optionally, irrigation apertures flank both sides of electrode **1008**.

(39) Referring to FIG. 11, a balloon **1100** includes an inflatable chamber **1101** and an electrode **1108**. Inflatable chamber **1101** includes four crinkled pleats **1110**, and electrode **1108** is disposed on inflatable chamber **1101** such that pleats **1110** flank both sides of electrode **1108**. In certain embodiments, inflatable chamber **1101** defines irrigation apertures. In some embodiments, at least a portion of each pleat **1110** is a substantially zig-zag pattern along the longitudinal axis of a cylindrical body portion of inflatable chamber **1101** when inflatable chamber **1101** is in the deflated state. In certain embodiments, at least a portion of one pleat **1110** is a spiral around a longitudinal axis of the cylindrical body portion when inflatable chamber **1101** is in the deflated state. In general, any suitable number of irrigation apertures may be included, at any reasonable positions and pleats **1110** may be folded in different orientations to avoid blocking the irrigation apertures during fluid flow.

(40) The systems, devices, methods, electrodes, inflatable chambers, and balloons described above may be incorporated into a system to provide, for example, renal denervation treatment.

(41) FIG. 12A illustrates an energy-delivery system **100** for providing renal neuromodulation according to some embodiments. The system **100** includes an energy delivery device **110**, energy generator **120**, and display **150**. The energy delivery device **110** can be, for example, any of the energy delivery devices described herein. In the example of system **100**, the energy-delivery device **110** is a balloon catheter sized for intravascular placement to deliver energy to neural fibers along a renal artery to modulate sympathetic renal nerve activity.

(42) The system **100** includes a user interface device **150** for communicating input and output information to the operator of the system. In some embodiments, the user interface device **150** is a display device. The display can be, for example, a touch screen interface for user input, and can display instructional messages and procedural feedback, such as power delivered, impedance, and

remaining treatment time. In some embodiments, the user interface device **150** communicates to the operator warning messages.

(43) The system **100** includes energy generator **120** which provides an energy signal the energy delivery device **110**. The energy generator **120** includes control circuitry and memory for controlling the operation of the system. The energy generator **120** can be coupled to the energy delivery device (and/or to the user interface device **150**) by wired or wireless link. In this example, the energy generator **120** is placed external to the patient.

(44) Although shown separately from the user interface device **150**, the energy generator **120** may be integrated with the user interface device **150** in a single housing. In some embodiments, the energy generator **120** includes memory, processing circuitry, firmware, and hardware for programming or controlling the system **100** to provide treatment to tissue. The energy generator **120** can provide any suitable type of energy signal to the energy delivery device **110**. In some embodiments, renal neuromodulation may be achieved via generation and/or application of thermal energy to the target neural fibers, such as through application of a an energy field, including, electromagnetic energy, radio frequency, ultrasound (including high-intensity focused ultrasound), microwave, light energy (including laser, infrared and near-infrared) etc., to the target neural fibers. For example, thermally-induced renal neuromodulation may be achieved via delivery of a pulsed or continuous thermal energy field to the target neural fibers. The energy field can be sufficient magnitude and/or duration to thermally induce the neuromodulation in the target fibers (e.g., to heat or thermally ablate or necrose the fibers).

(45) Without wishing to be bound by theory, it is believed that thermal ablation or non-ablative alteration of the target neural fibers at least partially denervates the kidney innervated by the neural fibers via heating. Thermal heating mechanisms for neuromodulation include both thermal ablation and non-ablative thermal alteration or damage (e.g., via sustained heating or resistive heating). Thermal heating mechanisms may include raising the temperature of target neural fibers above a desired threshold to achieve non-ablative thermal alteration, or above a higher temperature to achieve ablative thermal alteration. For example, the target temperature can be above body temperature (e.g., approximately 37 degrees C.) but less than about 45 degrees C. for non-ablative thermal alteration, or the target temperature can be about 45 degrees C. or higher for the ablative thermal alteration. The length of exposure to thermal stimuli may be specified to affect an extent or degree of efficacy of the thermal neuromodulation. For example, the duration of exposure can be as short as about 5, about 10, about 15, about 20, about 25, or about 30 seconds, or could be longer, such as about 1 minute, or even longer, such as about 2 minutes. Additionally or alternatively, the exposure can be intermittent or continuous to achieve the desired result.

(46) The energy delivery device **110** includes a catheter-mounted balloon **116** including an inflatable chamber **117** and an electrode **118** disposed on inflatable chamber **117**. The catheter-mounted balloon **116** is disposed on an elongate member **128**, which is a catheter. Inflatable chamber **117** defines irrigation apertures **138** and is, in some embodiments, an inflatable balloon.

(47) Catheter-mounted balloon **116** is delivered intravascularly via a guide catheter (not shown) and along a guidewire **140** in a folded configuration and is then inflated by flowing fluid (e.g., saline solution) to raise the pressure in inflatable chamber **117** and cause inflatable chamber **117** and electrode **118** to unfold. Inflatable chamber **117** may be made of non-elastic/non-compliant material or of compliant/elastic. Materials for a non-compliant inflatable chamber **117** include, without limitation, polyethylene, polyethylene terephthalate, polypropylene, cross-linked polyethylene, polyurethane, and polyimide. Materials for a compliant inflatable chamber **117** include, without limitation, nylon, silicon, latex, and polyurethane.

(48) Inflatable chamber **117** can be any suitable size. In some embodiments, the diameter (e.g., a diameter of a cylindrical body portion) of inflatable chamber **117** is about 4 mm to about 10 mm. In certain embodiments, the inflatable chamber **117** has a diameter (e.g., a diameter of a cylindrical body portion) of about 5 mm, about 6 mm, or about 7 mm. The axial length of the inflatable

chamber **117** can range from about 10 mm to about 50 mm. In some embodiments, the axial length of the inflatable chamber **117** is about 15 mm to about 30 mm. In some embodiments, the length of the inflatable element is about 20 mm. In certain embodiments, the axial length of the cylindrical intermediate portion of inflatable chamber **117** is between about 1 cm and about 4 cm. In some embodiments, the axial length of the cylindrical intermediate portion of the inflatable chamber **117** is about 20 mm and the diameter is about 5 mm to about 7 mm.

(49) The electrode **118** (e.g., a single helical electrode) is disposed on inflatable chamber **117** such that inflatable chamber **117** serves as a substrate for electrode **118**. In some embodiments, electrode **118** includes a helical section that makes about 0.5 revolutions to about 1.5 revolutions around inflatable chamber **117**. Electrode **118** can be formed, for example, by depositing a conductive material on the exterior wall of the inflatable chamber **117**, following depositing an insulation material on sections of the inflatable chamber **117**, leaving electrode **118** as the only substantially conductive surface on the portion of the catheter-mounted balloon **116** that is expected to come into contact with tissue.

(50) In some embodiments, portions of electrode **118** are covered by insulation material, forming a plurality of discrete conductive sections on electrode **118**. In such embodiments, a single conductor can be used to create a number of discrete burn zones following a helical path along and around a vessel wall. In use, these embodiments create a discontinuous helical burn pattern formed by a plurality of discrete burn areas in the tissue. The helical burn pattern can be formed during a single treatment session, and does not require the device be moved to create the plurality of discrete burn areas. Applicants have previously described mechanisms for generating various electrode patterns for use in renal neuromodulation in commonly owned and co-pending PCT/US2012/057967, filed on Sep. 28, 2012, which has been incorporated herein by reference in its entirety. Other electrodes (including probe-mounted electrodes) located within or outside of inflatable chamber **117** can additionally or alternatively be used.

(51) Irrigation apertures **138** include one or more holes (which may have any suitable size or shape) for providing protective irrigation to non-target tissue and/or cooling the electrode(s) in connection with renal neuromodulation. Irrigation apertures **138** can be defined along any suitable location on the inflatable chamber **117**, such as along the contours of and outside of electrode **118**, within the electrode(s) **118**, or elsewhere on inflatable chamber **117**.

(52) The system **100** can include a fluid reservoir (not shown) in fluid communication with the energy delivery device **110** via an irrigation line. Irrigation fluid from the fluid reservoir is delivered by a pump integrated with the energy generator **120**, and controlled by the same, to the energy delivery device **110** through an irrigation line. The irrigation fluid then flows out of the inflatable chamber **117** through the irrigation apertures **138**. The energy generator **120** controls operation of the pump to control the flow rate of the fluid from the reservoir into the inflatable chamber **117**. In some embodiments, the pump continuously pumps at a constant flow rate such that the flow is continuous from the reservoir. In certain embodiments, the pump is operated in an open loop constant flow configuration in which the pump rate is controlled by an over-pressure condition sensed by a pressure sensor (not shown), in which case the energy delivery is terminated, the pump is turned off, and an over-pressure condition reported to the operator. The pump is typically operated for a period of time which encompasses the delivery of the energy and turned off shortly after the conclusion of the procedure or if the pressure sensor senses an undesirable condition, as discussed in further detail below.

(53) The pressure sensor measures the operating pressure within inflatable chamber **117**, and may be adapted to determine if the pressure rises above or below threshold limits. The pressure can elevate if, for example, one or more of irrigation apertures **138** become blocked, preventing fluid from passing out of inflation chamber **117**, which can reduce cooling of electrode **118**. The memory of energy generator **120** can include computer-executable instructions, executable by control circuitry of energy generator **120**, to suspend (e.g., pause or terminate) delivery of energy to

electrode **118**, and to shut off the fluid pump if the fluid pressure rises above an established limit. In some embodiments, the pressure measured at the pressure sensor is driven by the fluid flow rate and the series sum of the fluid resistance of all of the elements in the fluid path. The choice of fluid flow rate may be affected by the required cooling rate and by the amount of irrigant fluid that can be tolerated by the patient.

(54) The operating pressure within inflatable chamber **117** may be affected by the fluid flow, the number of apertures **138**, and cross sections of irrigation apertures **138**. The distribution, number, and cross section of irrigation apertures **138** will be a function of the flow rate of irrigation fluid provided by the pump of energy generator **120**, the configuration of electrode **118**, the intended operating pressure, and the maximum desired exit velocity for the irrigation fluid at the treatment site.

(55) Device **110** can include at least one marker **127** disposed on catheter shaft **128** such that the marker is within inflatable chamber **117**. In some embodiments, marker **127** is a radio opaque marker (e.g., a marker including one or more of platinum and platinum-iridium). In certain embodiments, marker **127** also includes features viewable under fluoroscopy that allow, for example, for visualization of rotational orientation of marker **127**. This can facilitate location and/or realignment of the inflatable chamber **117** and electrode **118** by the operator within the renal artery.

(56) Referring to FIG. **12B**, an exemplary method is shown for using system **100** for a renal denervation procedure by application of RF energy to tissue in a renal artery. The method described herein can be carried out by other systems and by other energy-delivery devices, such as the other devices described herein. The energy-delivery device **110** is positioned in a renal artery using percutaneous access through a femoral artery. The inflatable element is delivered into the renal artery **1000** in a collapsed configuration (not shown). Fluid from the fluid reservoir is pumped (e.g., in an open loop control configuration, under constant flow) through the irrigation line and into the inflatable chamber **117** by the pump controlled by the energy generator **120** (FIG. **12A**). Fluid flow into inflatable chamber **117** causes inflatable chamber **117** to expand. Device **110** in FIG. **12B** is in a delivered, or expanded, configuration within renal artery **1000**. The tunica intima **1001** is surrounded by the tunica media **1002**, which is in turn surrounded by adventitial tissue **1003**. Tissue renal nerves **1004** are shown within the adventitial, and some renal nerves (not shown) are located within the tunica media.

(57) The fluid continually passes through apertures **138** in the inflatable chamber **117** as the fluid is replaced with new fluid from the fluid reservoir. Once fully expanded, electrode **118** on inflatable chamber **117** assumes a helical configuration as shown in FIG. **12A**. RF energy is delivered to electrode **118** on the inflatable chamber **117**. Energy generator **120** controls the parameters of the RF energy being delivered to the electrode **118** via conductive material carried by the catheter shaft **128**. In general, the RF signal characteristics are chosen to apply energy to depths at which the renal nerves are disposed to ablate the renal nerves. In general, the power is selected to ablate a majority of the renal nerves adjacent to where the device is positioned within the renal nerve. In some embodiments the tissue is ablated to a depth of between about 3 mm to about 7 mm from the tissue closest to the device in the renal artery.

(58) Tissue treated by the RF energy via the helical electrode is shown as regions **1005**, delineated by a dashed line. As illustrated, a region of treated tissue **1005** adjacent to the conductor **118** includes nerve **1004**. The device can be used in monopolar mode with a return electrode positioned somewhere on the patient's skin. However, it can also be used in bipolar mode without deviating from the scope of the disclosure.

(59) While several embodiments of the disclosure have been shown in the drawings and/or discussed herein, it is not intended that the disclosure be limited thereto, as it is intended that the disclosure be as broad in scope as the art will allow and that the specification be read likewise. Therefore, the above description should not be construed as limiting, but merely as

exemplifications of particular embodiments. Those skilled in the art will envision other modifications within the scope and spirit of the claims appended hereto.

Claims

1. A catheter-mounted balloon comprising: an inflatable chamber configured to expand from a deflated state to an inflated state, the inflatable chamber having at least one pleat zone, wherein the at least one pleat zone includes one or more pleats, wherein the inflatable chamber defines at least one irrigation aperture configured to allow fluid to flow from within the inflatable chamber to outside the inflatable chamber when the inflatable chamber is in the inflated state, and wherein all irrigation apertures defined by the inflatable chamber are unobstructed by the one or more pleats when the inflatable chamber is in a partially deflated state and when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state.
2. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein all irrigation apertures defined by the inflatable chamber and the one or more pleats are arranged to enable fluid to flow from within the inflatable chamber to outside the inflatable chamber through all irrigation apertures when the inflatable chamber is in the partially deflated state.
3. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein at least one pleat of the one or more pleats is configured to fold into a predetermined pleat pattern to avoid blocking at least one irrigation aperture during fluid flow.
4. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein the at least one pleat zone comprises a first pleat zone, a second pleat zone, and a third pleat zone each having a pleat that causes the inflatable chamber to collapse or fold along the pleat into a predetermined pleat pattern when the inflatable chamber is pushed through or pulled back into a guide catheter.
5. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein the at least one pleat zone defines an opening between a first internal side of one pleat of the one or more pleats and a second internal side of the one pleat of the one or more pleats when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state.
6. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein the inflatable chamber is collapsible along at least one pleat of the one or more pleats in response to a decrease in a volume of the inflatable chamber as the inflatable chamber is deflated from the inflated state to the deflated state.
7. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein the inflatable chamber has a distal transition portion, a proximal transition portion, and a cylindrical body portion disposed between the distal transition portion and the proximal transition portion.
8. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 7, wherein the at least one pleat zone includes a first pleat zone and a second pleat zone, and wherein the proximal transition portion includes a transition portion pleat disposed between the pleats of the first pleat zone and the second pleat zone, wherein the transition portion pleat extends between proximal and distal ends of the proximal transition portion substantially free of extension into the cylindrical body portion.
9. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 7, wherein at least one of the distal transition portion or the proximal transition portion of the inflatable chamber is frustoconically shaped.
10. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, further comprising at least one electrode on the inflatable chamber.
11. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 10, wherein at least one pleat of the one or more pleats traverses the at least one electrode such that the at least one electrode is pleated.
12. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 10, wherein the one or more pleats do not cross the at least one electrode such that the electrode is not pleated.
13. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 10, wherein the at least one electrode comprises a plurality of electrodes.
14. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 10, wherein the at least one irrigation aperture is disposed between one of the one or more pleats and a side of the at least one electrode.

15. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 10, wherein the one or more pleats include crinkled pleats configured to reduce a likelihood that electrical properties of the at least one electrode are compromised by the one or more pleats.
 16. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein the inflatable chamber comprises a layer of shape memory material.
 17. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein the one or more pleats are configured to be folded in different orientations to avoid occlusion of the at least one irrigation aperture.
 18. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein at least a portion of the one or more pleats is substantially parallel to the inflation chamber.
 19. The catheter-mounted balloon of claim 1, wherein at least a portion of the one or more pleats spirals around a longitudinal axis of the inflation chamber.
 20. A catheter comprising: a catheter body; and a balloon mounted on the catheter body, the balloon comprising: an inflatable chamber configured to expand from a deflated state to an inflated state, the inflatable chamber having at least one pleat zone, wherein the at least one pleat zone includes one or more pleats, wherein the inflatable chamber defines at least one irrigation aperture configured to allow fluid to flow from within the inflatable chamber to outside the inflatable chamber when the inflatable chamber is in the inflated state, and wherein all irrigation apertures defined by the inflatable chamber are unobstructed by the one or more pleats when the inflatable chamber is in a partially deflated state and when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state.
 21. The catheter of claim 20, wherein the one or more pleats are configured to be folded in different orientations to avoid occlusion of the at least one irrigation aperture.
 22. A catheter comprising: a catheter body; and a balloon at a distal portion of the catheter body, wherein the balloon comprises an inflatable chamber defining a volume expandable from a deflated state to an inflated state, the inflatable chamber having a distal transition portion, a proximal transition portion, and a cylindrical body portion disposed between the distal transition portion and the proximal transition portion, wherein the cylindrical body portion includes at least one pleat zone having one or more pleats, wherein the inflatable chamber defines at least one irrigation aperture configured to allow fluid to flow from within the inflatable chamber to outside the inflatable chamber when the inflatable chamber is in the inflated state, wherein all irrigation apertures defined by the inflatable chamber are unobstructed by the one or more pleats when the inflatable chamber is in a partially deflated state and when the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state.
 23. The catheter of claim 22, wherein all irrigation apertures defined by the inflatable chamber are configured to allow fluid to flow from within the inflatable chamber to outside the inflatable chamber when the inflatable chamber is in the partially deflated state.
 24. The catheter of claim 22, wherein at least one pleat of the one or more pleats is configured to fold into a predetermined pleat pattern to avoid blocking the at least one irrigation aperture.
 25. The catheter of claim 22, further comprising an electrode disposed along a wall of the inflatable chamber, wherein, in the inflated state, the inflatable chamber is configured to position the electrode in contact with an inner wall of a blood vessel.
 26. The catheter of claim 25, wherein the one or more pleats flank both sides of the electrode.
 27. The catheter of claim 22, wherein the balloon is configured for guidewire delivery to an intravascular treatment site within a blood vessel of a human patient while the inflatable chamber is in the deflated state, and wherein, when the inflatable chamber is in the inflated state, the cylindrical body portion including the at least one pleat zone has a consistent diameter between the proximal transition portion and the distal transition portion.
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